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Michigan City officials address privacy concerns as police consider expanding Flock Safety technology

By: Kylee Leahy.

Posted: Jun 29, 2026 11:40 PM EDT

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MICHIGAN CITY, Ind. -- Michigan City officials and representatives from Flock Safety met with residents Monday night to answer questions about the city's growing use of automated license plate reader cameras and discuss a proposed drone program aimed at speeding emergency response.

The Michigan City Police Department has used Flock Safety cameras since 2023, expanding from an initial 30 cameras to 60 point-in-time cameras across the city. Officials are now considering adding Flock's Drone as First Responder program.

"Our officers cannot possibly be everywhere at once," Assistant Police Chief Kyle Shiparski told residents during the meeting.

Under the proposed program, drones could be dispatched to emergency calls before officers arrive, providing video from the scene and helping police track fleeing suspects without initiating vehicle pursuits.

Andrew Blanchette, a territory sales manager with Flock Safety, pointed to South Bend's use of the technology as an example of its effectiveness.

"The first day that South Bend actually had their drone up and running, they had an individual who took off on a motorbike," Blanchette said. "The police were not able to get in a pursuit, they used the drone instead. When that person stopped, officers were able to arrest the individual, who had a stolen firearm from Mishawaka."

Police officials said the program could improve response times while helping a department that has previously dealt with staffing shortages.

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Several residents questioned what information the cameras collect and whether the technology captures more than license plate data.

A resident expressed concern about the camera angle, saying the elevated cameras appear capable of capturing much of a vehicle's interior.

Flock Safety representatives said the cameras collect publicly visible information, comparing the technology to "an officer standing by a roadway and taking pictures of license plates 24/7, 365."

The company said data collected by the cameras is not shared with the federal government, is only accessed as part of criminal investigations and is automatically deleted after 30 days under the terms of its contract with the city.

The city's current contract with Flock Safety costs approximately \$280,000 annually from the general fund.

Adding the Drone as First Responder program would increase that cost by about \$140,000 per year.

Police Chief Steve Forker said about 80% of the department currently uses Flock technology and noted that crime in Michigan City is down about 4% so far this year.

If city officials approve the drone program, funding would also come from the general fund.

During the meeting, one resident suggested Google, which plans to build a data center in Michigan City as part of Project Maize, could help cover the additional costs. Mayor Angie Nelson Deutch said that could be a possibility in the future, though no funding agreement has been announced.

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- 3 **SLIDESHOW: Friday weather's impact across Michiana**

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